

Practical, enterprise-style Sample Customer Support Playbook tailored for SQL Server Database Administration (DBA) Support.

We can adapt this for ITSM tools (ServiceNow, Jira), audits (ISO/SOC), or customer-facing SLAs.

SQL Server DBA Customer Support Playbook

1. Purpose & Scope

Purpose:

Ensure high availability, performance, security, and data integrity of SQL Server environments through structured support, escalation, and communication.

Scope:

- SQL Server (Standalone, Cluster, Always On, Azure SQL Managed Instance)
- Production, UAT, DR environments
- 24x7 support for critical systems

2. Support Hierarchy (Roles & Responsibilities)

Level-Based Support Model

Level	Role	Responsibility	Availability
L0	Monitoring / NOC	Alert monitoring, ticket logging, basic checks	24x7
L1	DBA Support Engineer	Basic troubleshooting, service restarts, health checks	24x7
L2	Senior DBA	Performance tuning, backups, restores, HA/DR issues	24x7 (On-call)
L3	DBA Architect / SME	Complex issues, root cause analysis, design fixes	Business hours + On-call
L4	Vendor / Microsoft	Product defects, escalation to MS Support	As needed

3. Support Team Structure

Core Support Teams

Team	Responsibilities
SQL Server DBA Team	DB availability, performance, backups, restores
Server / OS Team	Windows/Linux OS, patching, disk, CPU, memory
Storage Team	SAN/NAS, IOPS, latency, disk failures
Network Team	Connectivity, firewall rules, load balancers
Security Team	Access control, encryption, audits, vulnerability scans
Application Team	Application-level issues, query logic
DR / BCM Team	Disaster Recovery drills, failover testing

4. Incident Severity Levels (SLA)

Severity	Description	Example	Response Time	Resolution Target
Sev 1 (Critical)	Production down	SQL Server not accessible	15 mins	2 hrs
Sev 2 (High)	Major degradation	Severe slowness, blocking	30 mins	4 hrs
Sev 3 (Medium)	Partial impact	Job failures, reporting issue	2 hrs	1 business day
Sev 4 (Low)	Minor / Request	Index creation, access request	1 business day	Planned

5. Escalation Matrix (Contacts & Timings)

Escalation Flow

L1 DBA → L2 Senior DBA → L3 DBA Architect → IT Manager → Vendor (Microsoft)

Escalation Matrix Table

Level	Contact Role	Time to Escalate	Contact Window
L1	DBA Engineer	Immediate	24x7
L2	Senior DBA	After 30 mins (Sev 1)	24x7
L3	DBA Architect	After 1 hr (Sev 1)	On-call
L4	IT Ops Manager	After 2 hrs	Business hrs
Vendor	Microsoft Support	After internal RCA	As per contract

Note:

- Sev 1 incidents trigger **bridge call within 15 minutes**
- Customer communication every **30 minutes**

6. Server Downtime Management

Planned Downtime

Activity	Frequency	Notification
OS Patching	Monthly	7 days prior
SQL CU / SP	Quarterly	7 days prior
DR Drill	Semi-Annual	14 days prior

Process:

1. Change Request approved (CAB)
2. Pre-checks (Backups, Disk space)
3. Execution
4. Validation
5. Customer sign-off

Unplanned Downtime

Scenario	Action
SQL Service Crash	Restart service, analyze error logs
Disk Full	Expand disk, cleanup logs
Corruption	Restore from backup
HA Failover	Validate replicas

Communication Rule:

- Initial alert: **Within 15 minutes**
- Updates: **Every 30 minutes**
- RCA: **Within 48 hours**

7. SQL Server DBA Runbook (Quick Reference)

Daily Tasks

- Backup success verification
- SQL Agent job monitoring

- Disk space monitoring
- Replication / AG health checks

Weekly Tasks

- Index maintenance review
- Blocking & deadlock analysis
- Capacity trend analysis

Monthly Tasks

- Patch assessment
- Security review (logins, permissions)
- DR readiness check

8. Security & Access Management

Activity	Owner
Login creation	DBA + Security
Privilege review	Security Team
Encryption (TDE)	DBA
Auditing	Security

Principle: Least privilege & role-based access

9. Communication Template (Sev 1 Example)

Subject: Sev 1 – SQL Server Production Outage

Time: 14:05 UTC

Impact: Application unavailable

Current Status: Investigation in progress

Next Update: 14:35 UTC

10. Disaster Recovery (SQL Server)

Component	RPO	RTO
Critical DBs	15 mins	1 hr
Non-Critical	4 hrs	8 hrs

Technologies:

- Always On Availability Groups
- Log Shipping
- Azure Site Recovery

11. Key KPIs & Metrics

- Mean Time to Detect (MTTD)
- Mean Time to Resolve (MTTR)
- Backup Success Rate (%)
- Availability (%)
- Incident Recurrence Rate

12. Appendix – Example On-Call Roster

Role	Shift
L1 DBA	24x7 rotating
L2 DBA	On-call weekly
L3 Architect	Escalation only

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Cloud-specific, production-ready version of the Customer Support Playbook tailored separately for **Azure SQL** and **AWS RDS for SQL Server**, followed by **real-world escalation contact templates** we can directly plug into our ITSM / runbooks.

Cloud SQL Server DBA Support Playbook

(Azure SQL & AWS RDS SQL Server)

1. Cloud Responsibility Model (Critical Difference)

Shared Responsibility Overview

Area	Azure SQL	AWS RDS SQL Server
OS Patching	Microsoft	AWS
SQL Engine Patching	Microsoft	AWS
Backups	Microsoft (Automated)	AWS (Automated)
HA	Built-in (Zone redundant)	Multi-AZ
DR	Geo-Replication	Cross-Region Read Replica
User Security	Customer	Customer
Performance Tuning	Shared	Shared
Data Integrity	Customer	Customer

2. Cloud Support Hierarchy (Updated)

Level	Role	Cloud Responsibility
L0	Cloud Monitoring (Azure Monitor / CloudWatch)	Alerting, dashboards
L1	Cloud DBA	Query issues, parameter checks
L2	Senior Cloud DBA	Performance, failovers, scaling
L3	Cloud Architect	Architecture, capacity planning
L4	Cloud Vendor Support	Microsoft / AWS

3. Cloud Incident Severity & SLA (Cloud-Adjusted)

Severity	Impact	Response	Resolution Target
Sev 1	Azure SQL / RDS unreachable	15 mins	2 hrs
Sev 2	Performance degradation	30 mins	4 hrs
Sev 3	Job/Feature failure	2 hrs	1 business day
Sev 4	Enhancement	1 business day	Planned

4. Escalation Matrix – Azure SQL

Escalation Flow

Cloud Monitoring → L1 DBA → L2 Senior DBA → L3 Architect → Microsoft Support

Escalation Timings

Level	Trigger	Escalate After	Method
L1 DBA	Sev 1 alert	Immediate	Pager / Teams
L2 Senior DBA	No resolution	30 mins	Phone
L3 Architect	Major outage	1 hr	Phone
Microsoft Support	Platform issue	90 mins	Azure Support Ticket

5. Escalation Matrix – AWS RDS SQL Server

Escalation Flow

CloudWatch → L1 DBA → L2 Senior DBA → L3 Architect → AWS Support

Escalation Timings

Level	Trigger	Escalate After	Method
L1 DBA	Sev 1 alert	Immediate	Pager
L2 Senior DBA	No fix	30 mins	Phone
L3 Architect	Service impact	1 hr	Phone
AWS Support	Engine/infra issue	90 mins	AWS Support Case

6. Server Downtime – Cloud Specific

Planned Maintenance (Managed by Cloud Provider)

Platform	Maintenance Type	Notification
Azure SQL	Patching	35 days prior
AWS RDS	Maintenance window	Weekly window

DBA Actions:

- Validate maintenance window
- Notify application owners
- Post-maintenance validation

Unplanned Downtime (Cloud)

Scenario	Azure SQL	AWS RDS
Platform outage	Microsoft handles	AWS handles
Failover	Automatic	Multi-AZ
Storage latency	Microsoft	AWS
Query regression	DBA	DBA

Customer Updates: Every 30 minutes

7. Cloud DBA Runbook (Key Tasks)

Azure SQL

- Monitor DTU/vCore utilization
- Automatic tuning validation
- Geo-replication lag checks

- Azure Defender alerts

AWS RDS SQL Server

- Monitor CPU/IOPS/Memory
- Performance Insights review
- Parameter group validation
- Read replica lag checks

8. Cloud Security Responsibilities

Area	Azure SQL	AWS RDS
Encryption at Rest	TDE (Default)	AWS KMS
Encryption in Transit	TLS	TLS
Auditing	Azure SQL Auditing	RDS Audit Logs
Threat Detection	Azure Defender	GuardDuty

9. Disaster Recovery (Cloud)

Platform	RPO	RTO
Azure SQL Business Critical	< 5 mins	< 30 mins
AWS RDS Multi-AZ	< 5 mins	< 60 mins

Real Escalation Contact Templates

10. On-Call Escalation Contact Template

DBA On-Call Roster (Example)

Role	Name	Contact	Availability
L1 Cloud DBA	John Smith	+1-XXX-XXX-1111	24x7
L2 Senior DBA	Priya Patel	+1-XXX-XXX-2222	On-call
L3 Cloud Architect	Ahmed Khan	+1-XXX-XXX-3333	On-call
IT Ops Manager	Sarah Lee	+1-XXX-XXX-4444	Business hrs

11. Incident Bridge Call Template (Sev 1)

Subject: Sev 1 – Cloud SQL Production Outage

Bridge Line: +1-XXX-XXX-9999

Bridge ID: 123456

Timeline:

- Detection Time:
- Impacted Services:
- Current Status:
- Workaround:
- ETA:

12. Vendor Escalation Templates

Azure Support Ticket Template

Severity: Critical (A)

Service: Azure SQL Database

Region: East US

Issue: Database unreachable

Business Impact: Production outage

Requested Action: Immediate platform investigation

AWS Support Case Template

Severity: Business-Critical

Service: RDS SQL Server

Region: us-east-1

DB Instance ID: prod-sql-01

Impact: Production unavailable

Requested Action: Immediate AWS intervention

13. Customer Communication Template (Cloud)

Subject: Sev 1 – Cloud SQL Service Degradation

Start Time: 10:15 UTC

Impact: Application latency

Provider Status: Under investigation

Next Update: 10:45 UTC

14. Cloud KPIs & SLA Metrics

- Cloud Availability (%)
- Failover Success Rate
- Azure/AWS Support Response Time
- Query Regression Rate
- Cost vs Performance Efficiency

A production-grade, ServiceNow Incident Workflow plus Cloud SQL Cost Optimization & Auto-Scaling Runbooks specifically for Azure SQL and AWS RDS for SQL Server.

This is written so it can be **directly implemented** by ServiceNow admins and Cloud DBAs.

1. ServiceNow Incident Workflows

(Azure SQL & AWS RDS SQL Server)

1.1 Incident Lifecycle (ServiceNow)

Alert → Incident Creation → Classification → Assignment → Resolution → RCA → Closure

1.2 Automated Incident Creation (L0)

Trigger Sources

Platform	Monitoring Tool
Azure SQL	Azure Monitor, Log Analytics
AWS RDS	CloudWatch, EventBridge
APM	App Insights, Dynatrace, Datadog

ServiceNow Integration

- **MID Server or Event Management**
- Mapping alerts → CI → Service Offering

Auto-Created Fields

- Assignment Group: Cloud-DBA-L1
- Impact: High
- Urgency: High
- Priority: P1 (Sev 1)

1.3 Incident Categorization (Mandatory Fields)

Field	Value
Category	Database
Subcategory	SQL Server
CI Type	Azure SQL / AWS RDS
Environment	Prod / UAT / DR

1.4 Severity-Based Workflow

Sev 1 – Production Outage

Auto Actions

- Assign to Cloud-DBA-L1
- Trigger **On-Call Pager**
- Open **Bridge Call**
- Notify Cloud Architect

SLA Timers

- Response SLA: 15 mins
- Resolution SLA: 2 hrs

Escalation Rule

- 30 mins → Cloud-DBA-L2
- 60 mins → Cloud-Architect
- 90 mins → Vendor Support

Sev 2 – Performance Degradation

Step	Action
1	Assign to DBA L1
2	Performance analysis
3	Tune / Scale
4	Customer update

Sev 3 / Sev 4

- Routed via **Change Management**
- Scheduled resolution
- No bridge call

1.5 Vendor Escalation Workflow (Automated)**Azure SQL**

- Auto-generate **Azure Support Ticket**
- Attach:
 - Error messages
 - Query plans
 - DTU/vCore graphs

AWS RDS

- Auto-create **AWS Support Case**
- Attach:
 - CloudWatch metrics
 - Event logs
 - DB instance ID

1.6 Incident Closure Checklist (Mandatory)

- ✓ Root Cause Identified
- ✓ Resolution Documented
- ✓ Monitoring Updated
- ✓ Customer Confirmation
- ✓ RCA attached (Sev 1/2)

2. Cost Optimization Runbooks

(Azure SQL & AWS RDS SQL Server)

2.1 Azure SQL Cost Optimization Runbook**Key Cost Drivers**

- vCores / DTUs
- Storage

- Backup retention
- Geo-replication

Azure SQL Cost Optimization Steps

Step 1: Right-Sizing

- Review:
 - Avg CPU < 40%
 - Memory < 50%
- Action:
 - Scale down vCore / DTU
 - Move from Business Critical → General Purpose

Step 2: Elastic Pools

When to Use

- Multiple databases
- Variable workloads

Savings: 20–40%

Step 3: Auto-Pause (Serverless)

- Enable auto-pause (Non-prod)
- Idle time > 1 hr

Step 4: Storage Optimization

- Remove unused indexes
- Archive old data
- Reduce backup retention

2.2 AWS RDS SQL Server Cost Optimization Runbook

Key Cost Drivers

- Instance class
- IOPS
- Storage
- Licensing (SQL Enterprise vs Standard)

Optimization Steps

Step 1: Instance Right-Sizing

- CPU < 40%
- Freeable memory > 30%

Action: Move to smaller instance class

Step 2: Storage Optimization

- Switch from io1/io2 to gp3
- Reduce over-provisioned IOPS

Step 3: License Optimization

- Use **SQL Standard** where possible
- Consider **BYOL**

Step 4: Stop Non-Prod Instances

- Automated start/stop
- Savings up to 60%

3. Auto-Scaling Runbooks

(Safe Scaling Without Outages)

3.1 Azure SQL Auto-Scaling Runbook

Scaling Triggers

Metric	Threshold
CPU	> 80% for 15 mins
DTU	> 85%
Storage	> 80%

Auto-Scaling Process

1. Azure Monitor Alert
2. ServiceNow Change (Auto-Approved)
3. Scale up vCore/DTU
4. Validate workload
5. Notify stakeholders

Rollback: Scale down after 24 hrs

3.2 AWS RDS SQL Server Auto-Scaling Runbook

Scaling Triggers

Metric	Threshold
CPU	> 80%
Read Latency	> 20 ms
Free Storage	< 20%

Scaling Process

1. CloudWatch Alert
2. ServiceNow Change
3. Modify DB Instance
4. Multi-AZ failover (if required)
5. Validate application

Downtime: Minimal (failover)

4. Change Management Integration (ServiceNow)

Change Type	Use Case
Standard	Auto-scaling
Normal	Manual scale
Emergency	Sev 1 performance

5. KPIs & Cost Governance

Operational KPIs

- MTTR
- SLA compliance
- Incident recurrence

Cost KPIs

- Cost per database
- Cost vs utilization
- Monthly cloud spend reduction %

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Auto-Scaling Approval Matrix designed for **ServiceNow + Azure SQL + AWS RDS SQL Server**.

This is **audit-ready**, aligns with **ITIL / SOX / ISO**, and clearly separates **who can approve what, when, and under which conditions**.

Auto-Scaling Approval Matrix

(Azure SQL & AWS RDS SQL Server)

1. Approval Model Overview

Approval Types

Type	Description
Fully Automated	No human approval (pre-approved)
Conditional Auto-Approval	Auto-approved if conditions met
Manual Approval	Human approval required
Emergency Approval	Post-approval after action

2. Severity-Based Approval Matrix

2.1 Production – Sev 1 (Critical)

Scaling Action	Platform	Approval Type	Approver	Time
Scale Up Compute	Azure SQL	Emergency Auto	System	Immediate
Scale Up Instance	AWS RDS	Emergency Auto	System	Immediate
Storage Increase	Both	Emergency Auto	System	Immediate
Scale Down	Both	Manual	Cloud Architect	Post-Incident

Rule:

- Auto-scale allowed to **restore service**
- Post-incident **Change record mandatory**

2.2 Production – Sev 2 (High)

Scaling Action	Platform	Approval Type	Approver	SLA
Scale Up ($\leq 30\%$)	Azure SQL	Conditional Auto	ServiceNow	Immediate
Scale Up ($\leq 30\%$)	AWS RDS	Conditional Auto	ServiceNow	Immediate
Scale Up ($> 30\%$)	Both	Manual	Cloud Architect	30 mins
Storage Increase	Both	Manual	DBA Manager	30 mins

2.3 Production – Sev 3 (Medium)

Scaling Action	Platform	Approval Type	Approver	SLA
Scale Up	Both	Manual	Senior DBA	1 business hr
Scale Down	Both	Manual	Senior DBA	1 business hr
Instance Class Change	AWS	Manual	Cloud Architect	CAB

2.4 Non-Production (All Severities)

Action	Approval
Auto Scale Up	Fully Automated
Auto Scale Down	Fully Automated
Start/Stop	Fully Automated
Storage Increase	Conditional Auto

3. Cost-Based Approval Matrix

Monthly Cost Impact Thresholds

Cost Increase	Approval Required
< 5%	Auto-Approved
5–10%	DBA Manager
10–20%	Cloud Architect
> 20%	Finance + IT Director

4. Time-Based Approval Matrix

Time Window	Rule
Business Hours	Normal approvals
After Hours	Conditional auto
Weekend / Holiday	Emergency auto

5. Platform-Specific Rules

5.1 Azure SQL Auto-Scaling Approval Rules

Scenario	Approval
DTU/vCore $\uparrow \leq 30\%$	Conditional Auto
DTU/vCore $\uparrow > 30\%$	Manual
Tier Change (GP $\leftrightarrow$ BC)	Manual
Serverless Auto-Pause	Pre-Approved
Geo-Replica Scale	Manual

5.2 AWS RDS SQL Server Auto-Scaling Approval Rules

Scenario	Approval
Instance Scale Up (same family)	Conditional Auto
Instance Family Change	Manual
Storage Auto-Grow	Pre-Approved
IOPS Change	Manual
Multi-AZ Enable	Manual

6. ServiceNow Change Type Mapping

Scaling Action	Change Type
Auto Scale Up (Sev 1/2)	Emergency
Conditional Auto Scale	Standard
Planned Scale	Normal
Cost-Reduction Scale Down	Standard

7. Approval Authority Matrix (RACI)

Role	Approve	Execute	Review
Cloud DBA L1	✗	✓	✗
Senior DBA	✓	✓	✗
Cloud Architect	✓	✗	✓
IT Ops Manager	✓	✗	✓
Finance	✓	✗	✓

8. Auto-Scaling Guardrails (Mandatory)

- ✓ Max scale limit defined
- ✓ Cost ceiling enforced
- ✓ Auto-rollback enabled
- ✓ Monitoring updated
- ✓ Audit log captured

9. Post-Scaling Validation Checklist

Step	Owner
Performance validated	DBA
Cost impact reviewed	FinOps
Application health confirmed	App Team
Change record closed	ITSM

10. ServiceNow Flow Designer Logic (High-Level)

IF Severity = Sev1
 AND CPU > 80%
 THEN Auto-Scale
 AND Create Emergency Change
 AND Notify Architect

11. Executive Summary (For Policy Document)

Auto-scaling actions are governed by severity, cost impact, and environment.

Emergency scale-ups are pre-approved to restore service availability, while cost-impacting or architectural changes require formal approval.